

▶ HYDERABAD

BREAK TIME

During the 'silence period' between a high-octane campaign and voting, star campaigners in Telangana went off politics—well, almost. CM **Revanth Reddy** sported an INDIA jersey as he joined students playing his favourite sport, football, on the University of Hyderabad campus. AIMIM bossman **Asaduddin Owaisi**, meanwhile, took to street cricket for relaxation and rejuvenation near his home in Shastripuram, Hyderabad. ■

is not disappointing either. His friend, India's foreign minister **S. Jaishankar**, went to Amritsar to escort him as he filed his nomination papers on May 10. What's more, he endorsed one of Sandhu's commitments: of a US consulate being set up in the city. It may be a decision for Washington DC to make, but as Jaishankar said, "Americans have to open two more consulates in India. You have a good advocate to build your case." Sandhu was beaming sitting next to him. Sandhu is also a local, unlike past star candidates the BJP has fielded here—Arun Jaitley in 2014 and Sandhu's senior in the IFS, Hardeep Puri, in 2019. So he is also sharing ideas with local businesses and farmers on how to sell their produce—juttis, shawls, phulkaris, Amritsar's famous pappad and wadi, or fruits and vegetables—at megastores in the US and Europe or in lucrative West Asian markets. His wife Reenat Sandhu is presently ambassador at the Netherlands. And he flaunts his friendship with global CEOs, so that's a possible window to bring in corporations to invest here. ■





▶ WEST BENGAL

Flower Power

It's more usual to find thorny barbs being exchanged in West Bengal. And you can't fault Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury if he's always expecting a vitriolic word or two being hurled his way. The Congress warlord, fighting to keep Baharampur, gets as good as he gives. So the spectacle witnessed on May 11 went a bit against the grain. Adhir's motorcade happened to run into that of his BJP rival, Nirmal Chandra Saha. And...Saha threw flowers at Adhir! Both exchanged salutations with folded hands. Saha, a surgeon, apparently believes political rivalries should never impede personal relationships. Unlike the TMC's celeb candidate Yusuf Pathan, both are locals and have known each other for a long time. It didn't matter who you voted, the BJP or Trinamool, Adhir said the other day, cordiality outlives electoral competition. ■

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**